

Belarus holds drills with Russian nuclear weapons

By Reuters

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- Summary

- Exercise includes stealth movements of weapons across Belarus
- Lukashenko agreed in 2023 to host Russian tactical nuclear weapons
- Ukraine calls for tighter sanctions on Russia and Belarus

May 18 (Reuters) - Belarus said on Monday its armed forces had begun training exercises involving Russian nuclear weapons, in a move that drew strong condemnation from Ukraine.

Belarusian President Alexander Lukashenko agreed in 2023 - a year after Russia's invasion of Ukraine - to host Russian tactical nuclear missiles. Russian President Vladimir Putin has made clear that Moscow retains control of their use.

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"During the training, in cooperation with the Russian side, it is planned to practise the delivery of nuclear munitions and their preparation for use," the Belarusian Defence Ministry said in a statement.

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It said the exercise would test the military's readiness to deploy nuclear weapons in different areas of the country.

"The emphasis will be on practising stealth, movement over significant distances, and calculations for the use of forces and equipment," the ministry said.

Belarus - which shares borders with Russia, Ukraine and three NATO states - said the exercise was not aimed against any other country and did not pose security threats in the region.

Ukraine's Foreign Ministry urged Kyiv's Western allies to tighten sanctions against Russia and Belarus.

"By turning Belarus into its nuclear staging ground near NATO borders, the Kremlin is de facto legitimising the proliferation of nuclear weapons worldwide and setting a dangerous precedent for other authoritarian regimes," the Ukrainian ministry said.

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Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskiy said last week that Russia was seeking to draw Belarus deeper into its war in Ukraine, and was weighing plans to mount an attack from Belarusian territory on northern Ukraine or a NATO country.

Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov responded on Monday: "Such a statement is nothing other than an attempt at further incitement aimed at prolonging the war and escalating tensions."

Throughout the conflict, Putin has issued reminders of Russia's nuclear might that the West has seen as warnings not to intervene too deeply in support of Ukraine.

Last week, Putin said that Russia would deploy its new [Sarmat nuclear missile](#) by the end of the year, and that Moscow would continue to modernise its nuclear forces.

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